Indian students, who now number in excess of 100,000. The Indian community, the second most rapidly growing one, is a source of strength for both societies.

But it is really in the realm of politics and strategy that the transformation has been most evident. Much of the growing convergence has been driven by concerns about the region's stability, prosperity and security. The deficit in global goods has sought to be addressed by India and Australia working together bilaterally as well as in larger forums. This reflects their shared concerns about respect for international law and a rules-based order. The two countries may have long interacted in ASEAN-led forums, the Commonwealth, IORA, etc. But stronger leadership bonding and more open exchanges have brought out the mutual benefits of closer cooperation and coordination. Australia has been an early and vigorous supporter of India's IPOI. In fact, the big change has been the realization that a stronger bilateral relationship today allows the two nations to contribute much more effectively at a regional and a global level.

The new intensity in the interactions has been on display at the highest level, despite multiple changes at the Australian end. It is notable that their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership covers an annual meeting of PMs, a foreign minister's dialogue, a 2+2 ministerial mechanism, a trade ministerial commission, an education council, an energy dialogue and sectoral working groups. Clearly, the days of attention deficit are now over for good. Recent agreements range from maritime collaboration, defence science exchanges and mutual logistics support to cooperation in cyber-enabled critical technology, critical and strategic minerals, water resources management, migration and mobility, vocational education and training, as well as public administration and governance.

Some milestones do bring out the interactive dynamic between the bilateral and the regional facets of the relationship. Greater political confidence and deeper defence cooperation, for example, contributed to Australia joining Exercise Malabar. A better understanding on the space applications front led to the Australian support for the temporary Telemetry Tracking and Command Centre for the Gaganyaan Mission. A shared concern about trade reliability and economic volatility encouraged a partnership on the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative (SCRI), along with Japan. The conclusion of the Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA) in 2022 was not just a trade deal; it was an expression of systemic